

AI Literacy - Printable PDF

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FRONT MATTER

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CHAPTER 1

What Is AI Literacy?

AI literacy is the set of knowledge, skills, and habits of judgment that helps people understand, evaluate, use, and participate in decisions about artificial intelligence systems.

Being AI literate does not mean becoming a computer scientist. It means being able to recognize when AI is being used, understand what it can and cannot do, ask good questions, use it responsibly, and help shape how it affects daily life.

AI literacy matters because AI is increasingly present in:

- Education
- Workplaces
- Healthcare
- Media and information systems
- Banking and hiring
- Transportation
- Public services
- Customer support
- Entertainment and social platforms

As AI becomes more common, people need more than access to tools. They need the ability to use those tools wisely.

CHAPTER 2

A Simple Analogy: Learning to Drive a

Powerful Car

AI literacy is like learning to drive a powerful car.

You do not need to build the engine. But you do need to understand:

- The controls
- The speed and limits of the vehicle
- The safety rules
- The risks of poor use
- When to slow down
- When to let a human take control
- When conditions require extra caution

AI systems can be useful and powerful, but they still require informed human judgment.

CHAPTER 3

Why AI Literacy Matters

AI can help people write, search, analyze, translate, recommend, predict, summarize, create images, detect patterns, and automate tasks. But AI can also make mistakes, reflect bias, expose private information, or present uncertain outputs as if they are certain.

Broad AI literacy supports:

1. Informed Participation

People can better understand how AI affects their communities, workplaces, schools, and public services.

2. Safer Adoption

Users are more likely to notice risks, question outputs, protect personal information, and avoid overreliance.

3. More Equitable Outcomes

When more people understand AI, more people can participate in decisions about how it is designed, used, regulated, and evaluated.

4. Better Everyday Decisions

People can decide when AI is helpful, when it is inappropriate, and when human expertise is necessary.

CHAPTER 4

The Core Parts of AI Literacy

AI literacy includes four connected abilities:

4.1 1. Understanding AI

An AI-literate person can explain, in simple terms, what AI systems do.

This includes knowing that AI systems often work by identifying patterns in data and generating outputs based on those patterns. AI does not "understand" in the same way humans do, even when its responses sound fluent or confident.

Key questions:

- What is this AI system designed to do?
- What kind of data might it use?
- Is it making a prediction, recommendation, classification, or

generated response?

- Is a human reviewing the result?
-

4.2 2. Evaluating AI

AI outputs should not be accepted automatically. AI-literate users learn to evaluate results carefully.

This includes checking whether an output is:

- Accurate
- Relevant
- Current
- Fair
- Complete
- Transparent enough to understand
- Appropriate for the situation

Key questions:

- Could this answer be wrong?
 - What evidence supports it?
 - Are there missing perspectives?
 - Could the system be biased?
 - Should I verify this with another trusted source?
-

4.3 3. Using AI Responsibly

AI literacy includes practical skill. People should know how to use AI tools effectively while understanding their limits.

Responsible use includes:

- Giving clear instructions
- Checking outputs before relying on them
- Avoiding the sharing of sensitive personal information
- Understanding that AI can produce false or misleading content
- Knowing when human expertise is required
- Using AI as support, not as a substitute for responsibility

Key questions:

- Am I using this tool for a task it is suited to?
 - What information am I putting into the system?
 - Who could be affected by this output?
 - Do I need expert review?
-

4.4 4. Participating in Decisions About AI

AI affects society, not just individual users. AI literacy helps people participate in decisions about how AI should be used in schools, workplaces, healthcare, government, media, and public life.

This includes asking about:

- Privacy
- Bias
- Transparency
- Accountability
- Human oversight
- Safety
- Fair access

- The right to question or appeal AI-assisted decisions

Key questions:

- Who benefits from this AI system?
 - Who might be harmed?
 - Who is responsible if something goes wrong?
 - Can people understand or challenge the decision?
 - Is there meaningful human oversight?
-

CHAPTER 5

What AI Can Do Well

AI can be useful for many tasks, especially when the task involves patterns, language, classification, or large amounts of information.

Examples include:

- Summarizing long documents
- Drafting text
- Translating languages
- Finding patterns in data
- Generating study questions
- Supporting brainstorming
- Organizing information
- Assisting with accessibility tools
- Helping detect unusual activity or trends

AI can be especially helpful when used as a first draft, assistant, or support tool.

CHAPTER 6

What AI Cannot Reliably Do

AI has important limits. It can produce results that look polished but are still wrong.

AI may struggle with:

- Understanding real-world context
- Explaining how it reached a result
- Knowing whether information is current
- Recognizing its own mistakes
- Handling unusual cases
- Making moral or legal judgments
- Representing all groups fairly
- Protecting privacy unless systems are designed and used carefully

AI should not be treated as automatically objective, neutral, or correct.

CHAPTER 7

Responsible Judgment: The Human Role

Responsible AI use requires human judgment. This is especially important when AI is used in high-impact areas such as:

- Medical care
- Hiring
- Education decisions

- Legal processes
- Banking or loans
- Government benefits
- Public safety
- Child protection
- News and political information

In these areas, mistakes can affect people's rights, health, opportunities, or safety. Human oversight is essential.

CHAPTER 8

Privacy, Bias, Transparency, and Accountability

AI literacy includes understanding several major concerns.

8.1 Privacy

AI systems may process personal or sensitive information. Users should be careful about entering:

- Medical details
- Financial information
- Identification numbers
- Private messages
- Workplace secrets
- Student or client records

Good habit: If you would not post it publicly or share it with an unknown company, think carefully before entering it into an AI

tool.

8.2 Bias

AI systems can reflect or amplify unfair patterns found in data or design choices. Bias can affect decisions about hiring, lending, healthcare, policing, education, and online content.

Good habit: Ask whether different groups of people might be affected differently by the system.

8.3 Transparency

Transparency means people should be able to know when AI is being used and understand enough about how it works to question or evaluate it.

Good habit: Look for clear explanations of what the system does, what data it uses, and what its limits are.

8.4 Accountability

Accountability means someone must be responsible for how AI is used and what happens when it causes harm.

Good habit: Ask who is responsible if the AI output is wrong, unfair, unsafe, or harmful.

8.5 Human Oversight

Human oversight means people remain involved in reviewing, correcting, and controlling AI-assisted decisions.

Good habit: In important decisions, AI should support human judgment, not replace it completely.

CHAPTER 9

How to Evaluate an AI Output

Use this simple checklist before trusting or sharing an AI-generated result.

9.1 The AI Output Check

Ask:

1. Is it accurate?

Can I verify it with a reliable source?

2. Is it complete?

What might be missing?

3. Is it current?

Could the information be outdated?

4. Is it biased?

Are some people, groups, or viewpoints unfairly represented?

5. Is it appropriate?

Should AI be used for this task at all?

6. Is it safe to use?

Could someone be harmed if this is wrong?

7. Do I need a human expert?

Is this a medical, legal, financial, educational, or safety-related decision?

CHAPTER 10

Everyday Examples of AI Literacy

10.1 Example 1: Using AI to Write an Email

AI can help draft a polite message.

An AI-literate user reviews the draft, checks tone, removes private information, and makes sure the message reflects their own intent.

10.2 Example 2: Seeing a News Recommendation

A social media platform recommends a video or article.

An AI-literate user understands that recommendations may be shaped by engagement patterns, not necessarily by accuracy or public importance.

10.3 Example 3: Getting Health Information

AI provides a possible explanation for symptoms.

An AI-literate user treats the answer as general information, not a

diagnosis, and consults a qualified healthcare professional when needed.

10.4 Example 4: AI in Hiring

An employer uses AI to screen applications.

An AI-literate public asks whether the system has been tested for fairness, whether applicants are informed, and whether humans review decisions.

10.5 Example 5: Schoolwork and Learning

A student uses AI to explain a concept.

An AI-literate student compares the explanation with class materials, asks follow-up questions, and avoids submitting AI-generated work as their own if that violates rules.

CHAPTER 11

Practical Skills for AI-Literate Users

To build AI literacy, practice the following skills:

- Recognize when AI may be involved
- Ask what the system is designed to do
- Give clear instructions when using AI tools
- Check results against reliable sources
- Watch for bias or missing context

- Protect personal and sensitive information
 - Understand when expert help is needed
 - Question high-stakes AI decisions
 - Support transparency and accountability
 - Keep humans responsible for important judgments
-

CHAPTER 12

A Beginner's Guide to Using AI Well

When using an AI tool, try this process:

12.1 1. Define the Task

Be clear about what you want.

Instead of:

"Help me with this."

Try:

"Summarize this article in five bullet points for a general audience."

12.2 2. Provide Context Carefully

Give enough information to improve the answer, but avoid unnecessary private details.

12.3 3. Ask for Limits

You can ask the AI to state uncertainty, assumptions, or missing information.

Example:

"What are the limitations of this answer?"

12.4 4. Verify Important Claims

For factual, medical, legal, financial, or safety-related information, check trusted sources or ask a qualified expert.

12.5 5. Make the Final Decision Yourself

AI can assist, but people remain responsible for how its outputs are used.

CHAPTER 13

AI Literacy Is Not Just Technical

Effective AI literacy combines:

- Technical understanding: What AI systems do and how they may work
- Practical capability: How to use AI tools effectively
- Critical evaluation: How to judge outputs and identify limitations
- Ethical reasoning: How to consider fairness, privacy, accountability, and harm

- Civic participation: How to take part in decisions about AI in society

The goal is not fear of AI or blind excitement about AI. The goal is informed, responsible participation.

CHAPTER 14

Common Misunderstandings About AI

14.1 Misunderstanding 1: "AI is always objective."

AI systems can reflect the data, assumptions, and design choices behind them. They can produce biased or unfair results.

14.2 Misunderstanding 2: "If AI sounds confident, it must be right."

AI can generate fluent and convincing text that is still inaccurate.

14.3 Misunderstanding 3: "AI understands like a human."

AI systems can process and generate patterns in language, images, or data, but this is not the same as human understanding, lived experience, or moral judgment.

14.4 Misunderstanding 4: "AI decisions do not need human review."

In important situations, human oversight is necessary to protect safety, fairness, and accountability.

14.5 Misunderstanding 5: "AI literacy is only for experts."

AI literacy is for everyone because AI increasingly affects everyday life.

CHAPTER 15

Questions Every Citizen Should Be Able to Ask

When AI is used in a school, workplace, hospital, government office, or online platform, people should be able to ask:

- Is AI being used here?
- What is the AI system doing?
- What data does it rely on?
- How accurate is it?
- Has it been tested for bias?
- Who is responsible for the outcome?
- Can a human review the decision?
- Can affected people appeal or challenge the result?
- What privacy protections are in place?

- Is this use of AI appropriate?

These questions help communities make better decisions about AI adoption.

CHAPTER 16

Quick Reference: AI Literacy Checklist

Before trusting or using AI, remember:

- Recognize it: Is AI involved?
 - Understand it: What is it designed to do?
 - Question it: What could be wrong or missing?
 - Verify it: Can reliable sources confirm it?
 - Protect privacy: Am I sharing sensitive information?
 - Check fairness: Could this affect people unequally?
 - Demand accountability: Who is responsible?
 - Keep humans involved: Does this decision need human judgment?
-

CHAPTER 17

Memorable Takeaway

AI literacy means knowing enough to use AI helpfully, question it wisely, and keep humans responsible where it matters most.

Like driving a powerful car, you do not need to build the engine-but you do need to know the controls, the limits, the safety

rules, and when a human must pay close attention.

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